

folder with what kind of contents you want inside (say everything related to *The Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy*), keep it overnight and blinkx will spider both online and offline information on your topic and gather links to everything relevant inside the Smart Folder...

Data deluge is part for the tech course we are headed on. It is indeed nice to have a good search companion by your side to make sense of the chaos. Here's to desktop search tools, may their tribe increase!

TECHNOLOGY > SUB 1-INCH HARD DISKS

The Incredibly Shrinking Hard Disk

The proliferation of portable devices has triggered a demand for high-capacity storage in a small form-factor. Last year, Hitachi unveiled its Microdrive, 1-inch platters spinning at its heart. But the future is even smaller.

Toshiba and Matsushita, for example have hard disks based on 0.8-inch and 0.7-inch diameter platters—that's about half the 1.8-inch drives currently inside the Apple iPod. So where is the demand coming from?

Mostly from consumer devices, and not just the traditional laptops and portable music players... as mentioned earlier, cameras are adopting hard disks. So will PDAs, in time. Similarly, there is a mini-boom in the handheld-PC market—products such as the OQO model 01, the FlipStart, the Sony U50, and U750P, the FlyBook, the Tigit, the Antelope—these so-called “hand-tops” demand high-capacity storage in a handheld-friendly form-factor.

Handtops are smaller than laptops and run Microsoft Windows powered by a low-power processor such as a Transmeta. This new breed will consume miniature hard disks with ease. Industry estimates suggest that the consumer appliance segment of the hard drive market, could account for as much as half of the

demand for storage media by 2007.

With moving video on cell phones, PDAs, and Portable Media Center devices, flash-based memory will no longer be cost effective—earlier last year; the price for a 1 GB Microdrive was around US \$159, while the cheapest 1 GB CompactFlash card sold for about US \$205. Indeed, the demand for small hard disks (mainly from the runaway success of the iPod) had prompted Toshiba to double production of its 1.8-inch hard disk drive to 600,000 units per month.

EVENT > LINUX SHAKES THINGS UP

Linux vs The Rest of The World

There is little doubt that Linux has arrived in the server space, what is interesting to note is that Linux is now synonymous with Red Hat in that market. This equation has traditional players in the server market worried. Sun, Microsoft and Novell to name the largest: alliances and take-overs were the order of 2004, then.

Novell got the ball rolling by first purchasing Ximian, makers of the “Microsoft Outlook-killer,” the Evolution e-mail client for GNU/Linux. Ximian's Red Carpet distribution system was also a factor to the purchase. Novell then bought SuSE which makes a very compelling Linux distribution, especially with its set of YaST configuration tools. With the two under its belt, Novell is all set to integrate its own Netware solutions and offer—they hope—a comprehensive and attractive package for the server space.

Meanwhile, Sun and Microsoft have signed a togetherness pact, the impact of which will undoubtedly resonate beyond 2004. What brought them together were the trio of threats of IBM, Red Hat and that whole Open Source bag of trouble... Their alliance, as of now extends to covering each others backs as per software patents and a currently cloudy (in terms of execution, not goal) intention of aligning Sun's offerings with Microsoft's, with comprehensive once again being central to the plan.

There will be much competition past 2004—brought to you by IBM, Sun, Microsoft, Red Hat, and the wonder child of a million programmers—GNU/Linux.

PEOPLE > SRINIDHI VARADARAJAN, PROJECT LEADER OF A TOP 10 SUPERCOMPUTER

Big Mac—35 Teraflops Served

MIT's Technology Review magazine undertakes an annual ritual of creating lists. These are not of the “top 10 vacation spots for quantum physicists” variety but the more prosaic, albeit eminently more practical list of 100 Top Young Innovators of 2004 (young is relative, as MIT professors will tell you, here it means under the age of 35).

One such blip on their radar was made by Srinidhi Varadarajan. To learn of the why behind the wow, we take you back to 2003...

When you hear “supercomputer”, huge monolithic machines masked in black and towering formidably over all they survey, spring to mind. You don't think shiny personal computers; you especially do not think Apple computers. Well, start thinking.



According to Seagate, within two years, storage prices will fall to levels indicated above